
The Open-Book Stretch Deep Dive

The one stretch I assign more than any other —
done right

NATE RATCLIFF, LMT

The Open-Book Stretch Deep Dive

The one stretch I assign more than any
other — done right

NATE RATCLIFF, LMT

HEALING HANDS BY NATE

The Open-Book Stretch Deep Dive

© 2026 Healing Hands By Nate. All rights reserved.

Nate Ratcliff, LMT

Between Sessions Bonus — Month 4 (April)

For Healing Hands By Nate Between Sessions members. Personal use only. Please don't redistribute — share the membership instead.

Published by Healing Hands By Nate

Contents

1. Why this stretch specifically
2. The setup (which most people get wrong)
3. The actual move
4. Common mistakes (and how to fix them)
5. Progressions (when the basic version gets easy)
6. Dose
7. What to expect
8. Closing

Introduction

A BETWEEN SESSIONS BONUS PROTOCOL — THE single most effective thoracic mobility exercise, done right and held progressively.

This is the stretch I assign more than any other. If you only do one thing from this whole membership, make it this.

The open-book stretch shows up in every other module I've written because it's that important. Tight mid-back? Open-book. Locked shoulders? Open-book. Shallow breathing? Open-book. Forward head posture? Open-book. The same five-minute stretch reliably moves the needle on more upper-body complaints than any other single move I know.

But here's the thing: most people do it wrong. They cheat the form. They rush through it. They miss the progressions that make it really work. They feel underwhelmed because they're not actually getting the benefit.

This deep dive fixes that. By the end, you'll know exactly how to do the open-book stretch right, what

mistakes to watch for, and how to progress it as your body opens up.

CHAPTER 1

Why this stretch specifically

MOST STRETCHES ADDRESS ONE TISSUE. THE open-book stretch addresses the entire upper-body pattern in a single move:

- **Thoracic spine rotation** — restores the rotational range most adults have lost
- **Chest opening** — counteracts the forward-rounded shoulder posture
- **Lat lengthening** — releases the muscle on the side of your back that pulls your shoulder forward
- **Rib cage mobility** — improves rib-to-spine articulation, which improves breath depth
- **Cervical spine release** — the head-turning component restores neck rotation
- **Hip stabilization** — the lower body's anchor position teaches the hips to hold while the upper body moves

Six benefits in one stretch. Done twice a day, five reps each side, takes maybe 4 minutes total.

That's the leverage. That's why I assign it more than anything else.

CHAPTER 2

The setup (which most people get wrong)

THIS IS WHERE THE FORM STARTS BREAKING down. Get the setup right and the stretch works. Get it wrong and you'll feel nothing useful.

1. Lie on your side on the floor. Not on your bed. Not on a couch. A firm flat surface. The mattress or cushion lets your hips shift around and ruins the stabilization.

2. Knees stacked at exactly 90 degrees. This is the part most people fudge.

- Hips bent at 90 degrees (not less, not more)
- Knees bent at 90 degrees
- Legs perfectly stacked on top of each other
- Top knee should land directly over bottom knee

The 90-degree position is what locks your hips and pelvis in place. Without that lock, your upper body rotation just turns into hip rotation and you're not actu-

ally stretching your mid-back — you're stretching nothing useful.

3. Both arms straight out in front of you, palms together. Arms at shoulder height, perpendicular to your body. Hands stacked palm-to-palm.

4. Head resting on a small pillow or your bottom arm. Don't strain your neck holding your head up. Use support.

That's the setup. Spend 30 seconds making sure all four things are right BEFORE you start the actual stretch. Most people skip this and lose 70% of the benefit.

CHAPTER 3

The actual move

ONCE YOU'RE SET UP:

1. Slowly slide your top hand along your bottom arm toward your shoulder. This warms up the motion.

2. As your hand reaches your bottom shoulder, start lifting it. Keep your eyes on your hand the whole time — your head will turn with the arm.

3. Continue rotating your top arm in an arc over your body, like you're turning the page of a book. Eyes follow the hand.

4. Let your chest open as your arm rotates. The rib cage twists open with the arm.

5. Stop when your top hand reaches the floor behind you — OR — when you've gone as far as your body comfortably allows. Whichever comes first.

6. Hold the end position for 2-3 slow breaths. Breathe INTO the stretched side. Feel the chest open further with each inhale.

7. Slowly reverse the motion — top hand back over the body, returning to palms-together starting position. Eyes follow the hand back.

8. Repeat 4 more times on this side. Then switch sides.

CHAPTER 4

Common mistakes (and how to fix them)

Mistake 1 — Forcing the shoulder to the floor

SOME YOUTUBE VIDEOS SHOW PEOPLE WHOSE top shoulder lies flat on the floor in the end position. That's not the goal. That's just what someone with a flexible mid-back can do.

If you force your top shoulder to the floor and your knees come off each other or your hips shift, you've broken the stretch. The hips **MUST** stay stacked.

Fix: let your top shoulder land wherever it naturally lands while keeping the hip lock. Maybe that's the floor. Maybe that's 6 inches off the floor. Maybe that's a foot off the floor. Doesn't matter. The hip stability matters.

Mistake 2 — Holding your breath

People concentrate hard on the form and stop breathing. Then they wonder why the stretch feels stuck.

Fix: deliberate breath through the whole motion. Inhale as you start the rotation. Exhale at the end of the

rotation. Inhale-exhale-inhale-exhale during the hold. The breath is what releases the tissue.

Mistake 3 — Going too fast

Five reps in 30 seconds isn't this stretch. That's a warm-up. The actual stretch is slow — each rep takes 15-20 seconds with the hold.

Fix: count slowly through each phase. 4 counts to rotate out, 6 counts to hold at the end, 4 counts to rotate back. That's per rep.

Mistake 4 — Skipping the eye component

Your eyes drive your head turn. Your head turn drives your neck rotation. If you're not letting your eyes follow your hand, you're missing the cervical spine component.

Fix: keep your eyes locked on your moving hand the entire time. The head turn happens automatically.

CHAPTER 5

Progressions (when the basic version gets easy)

THE STANDARD OPEN-BOOK STRETCH STARTS TO feel less intense after 2-3 weeks of daily practice. That's good news — it means your mid-back is opening. Time to progress.

Progression 1 — Add a longer end-range hold

Same setup, same motion. But instead of 2-3 breaths at the end position, hold for 5-6 breaths.

The longer hold lets your nervous system register the new range as “safe” and adopt it as the new normal. The stretch literally rewires your range of motion.

Progression 2 — Add breathing into the stretched side

At the end position, place your top hand on the side of your rib cage (the upper side, which is now stretched open). Direct your inhale specifically into that area. Feel the rib cage expand against your hand.

This progression targets the rib-to-spine articulation that's even harder to access than the basic thoracic rotation.

Progression 3 — The “reach” variation

At the end position, with your top arm extended, REACH the fingertips further away from your body. As if you're trying to touch a wall 6 inches further than you can reach.

The reach lengthens the lat (the muscle along the side of your back) more aggressively. This is where you'll feel the stretch jump from “good” to “intense” if you're ready for it.

Progression 4 — Add bottom-leg straightening (advanced)

Once you're comfortable with the previous progressions, you can try straightening the bottom leg (still keeping the top leg bent at 90 degrees with the foot resting on the floor in front of you for stability).

This changes the pelvic position and adds a deeper lumbar/hip component to the stretch. Only attempt after the basic version is easy.

CHAPTER 6

Dose

DAILY MINIMUM: 5 REPS EACH SIDE, ONCE A DAY.
Roughly 2 minutes.

Recommended: 5 reps each side, twice a day. Once in the morning, once before bed. Roughly 4 minutes total.

Therapeutic (for active mid-back stiffness): 5 reps each side, three times a day, with progressions added. Roughly 8-10 minutes total.

There's no benefit to doing it more than 3 times a day. The tissue needs recovery time between exposures.

CHAPTER 7

What to expect

BY DAY 5-7 OF CONSISTENT PRACTICE, MOST people report:

- Easier deep breaths
- Less shoulder tightness
- A feeling of “openness” through the chest
- Better awareness of posture throughout the day

By week 3, the gains become structural rather than just temporary. Your default posture starts changing. Your chest stays more open even when you’re not actively stretching.

By month 2, most of the chronic upper-body complaints that the open-book stretch addresses are notably reduced. Not because anything dramatic happened — because consistent daily mobility work compounds.

CHAPTER 8

Closing

FIVE EACH SIDE, TWICE A DAY. YOUR MID-BACK, your shoulders, and your breathing will all change within two weeks.

This is the most leveraged stretch I know. The ratio of time invested to benefit produced is unmatched in anything else I assign. Four minutes a day. Real, durable, structural change.

If you've been skipping it because it seems too simple to matter, this is your reminder: do it tonight. Both sides. Five reps. See for yourself.

— Nate



This book was crafted by Nate Ratcliff,
LMT and published by Healing Hands By
Nate.